

Balancing the structure

There are a number of considerations that can help you to strike this balance. First, while an appropriate structure is essential for an innovation idea to progress, rigid hierarchies can stifle new ideas, as employees at lower levels find themselves unable to pass their suggestions on to management. Cooperation across team boundaries is essential, since input from many different skill sets will be needed to implement a new idea—this cannot be achieved if each department operates on its own. Good communication across the organization is equally important, as well as communication up and down the hierarchy, so that ideas can be shared, and no one feels left out as an innovation moves forward. The structure of individual teams is also important. Effective team-working means that ideas are discussed and developed within a team, and all team members are encouraged to contribute. Ensure that all teams are aware their input is welcome, rather than treating innovation as a job for the experts.

TIP

TRAIN YOUR EMPLOYEES

Make sure your staff receives necessary training to understand the innovation processes in which they are involved, since this will help them generate ideas and take on new processes easily.



ASK YOURSELF... DOES YOUR ORGANIZATION PROMOTE INNOVATION?

- Does the organizational structure facilitate innovation rather than stifling it?
- Do people work well together across departmental boundaries?
- Is there a strong commitment to training and development of people?
- Are our people involved in suggesting ideas for improvements to products or processes?
- Does our structure help us to make decisions rapidly?
- Is communication effective, and does it work top-down, bottom-up, and across the organization?
- Does our reward and recognition system support innovation?
- Do we have a supportive climate for new ideas, so that people do not have to leave the organization to make them happen?
- Do we work well in teams?